

Polar habitats

In winter, there is little sunlight near the cold North and South poles. In summer, the seas teem with life, which supports large numbers of fish and other animals. Many land animals live in the Arctic, but only a few tiny invertebrates live in Antarctica.

WHERE ON EARTH?

The polar regions consist of the Arctic Ocean and nearby land, and the continent of Antarctica and the surrounding ocean. Large areas of the seas in these regions are frozen in winter.



POLAR REGIONS

There are two different polar regions on Earth. The Arctic is at Earth's North Pole, and Antarctica at the South Pole.



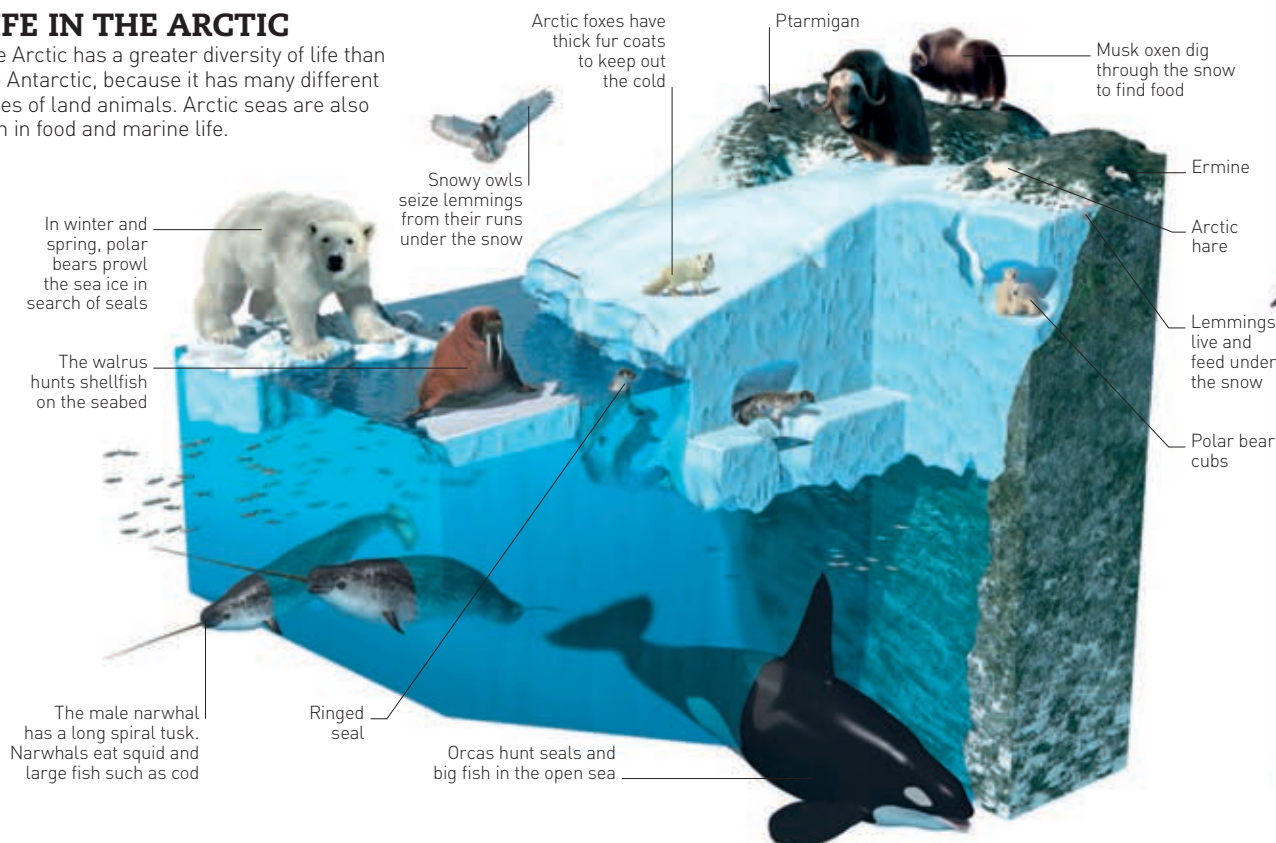
THE ARCTIC
The Arctic is an icy ocean with land all around it, where animals can live.



ANTARCTICA
Antarctica is an icy continent, and most of its animals live in the ocean.

LIFE IN THE ARCTIC

The Arctic has a greater diversity of life than the Antarctic, because it has many different types of land animals. Arctic seas are also rich in food and marine life.



POLAR SEASONS

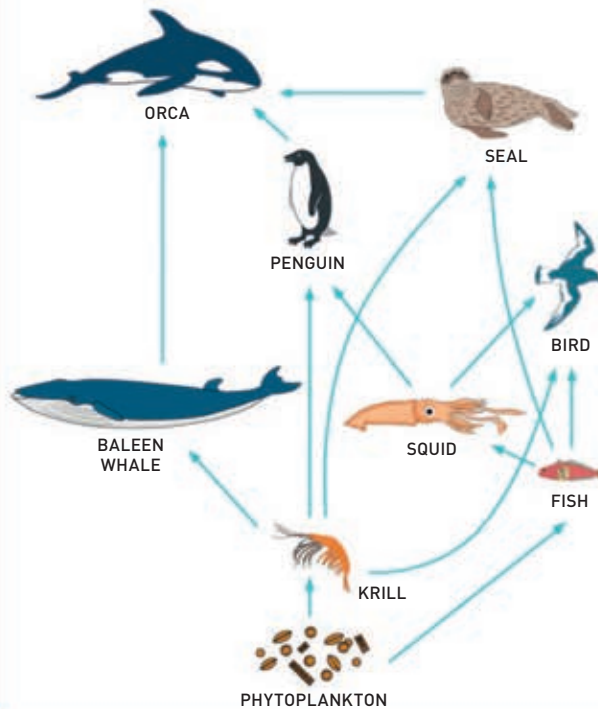
As Earth spins, most places experience day and night. But because of the tilt of Earth's axis, the polar regions are always dark in midwinter, and stay light in midsummer. This is one reason why polar winters are so bitterly cold.



NORTHERN WINTER
In December, the Arctic is in almost constant darkness.

FOOD WEB

In the Antarctic, all the animals get their food from the sea. Tiny drifting algae [phytoplankton] feed swarms of krill, which are in turn eaten by baleen whales, seals, penguins, and birds. Fish are eaten by seals and birds, while orcas eat anything they can catch.



LAND MAMMALS

The Arctic is the only polar region with land mammals. Some are summer visitors, but others such as the musk ox live in the Arctic all year round. Polar bears live mainly on the sea ice.

ARCTIC HARE



COLLARED PIKA



SNOWSHOE HARE



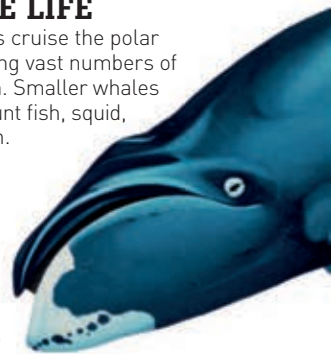
ERMINE



ARCTIC LEMMING

MARINE LIFE

Giant whales cruise the polar oceans, eating vast numbers of krill and fish. Smaller whales and seals hunt fish, squid, and shellfish.



BOWHEAD WHALE

BIRDS

Many land birds range over the Arctic, but all Antarctic birds, such as penguins, find their food in the ocean.



ALBATROSS



SNOWY OWL



PEREGRINE FALCON